Calling costs: Plivo and LiveKit

What the phone line (Plivo) and the call media service (LiveKit) cost at each scaling step, how much of it is fixed, and which of their limits must be raised as customers grow.

~INR 3	~INR 2.5	$0–500 / mo
Plivo + LiveKit per employee per month	Plivo + LiveKit per phone call (~3.5 min)	The truly fixed part: LiveKit plan fee, plus INR 200 per Plivo number

Scope. Plivo and LiveKit only, at their published list prices (checked 27 Oct 2026), before GST, INR at ~88 per dollar. Companion to *azure-capacity-and-cost.pdf*, which covers Azure and uses the same steps and assumptions. Not included: WhatsApp (Meta), Sarvam speech, Azure OpenAI tokens.

Can these be counted as fixed charges?

Mostly no. Only a small part of each bill is fixed. At any real volume, 90% or more is charged per minute of calling:

Service	Fixed each month	Charged per use
Plivo (phone line)	Number rental: INR 200 per number	INR 0.38 a minute, both directions, billed in 30-second pulses
LiveKit (call media)	Plan fee: $0 Build, $50 Ship, $500 Scale, custom Enterprise	Minutes beyond the plan's included amount: SIP $0.004 (Ship) or $0.003 (Scale), WebRTC $0.0005 or $0.0004

They are, however, **predictable**, because call volume follows headcount. With about 5% of employees called each working day, an employee generates ~1.1 calls a month, so the two services together cost about **INR 3 per employee per month**. The right way to treat them as "fixed" is as a per-customer cost built into pricing, not as platform overhead.

At a glance

Step	Built for	LiveKit plan	Plivo / month	LiveKit / month	Together / month
Today	One 1,000-employee company	Ship (Build is too small)	~INR 1,700	~$50	~INR 6,100 ($69)
Step 1	One 10,000-employee company	Ship	~INR 15,600	~$205	~INR 33,700 ($383)
Step 2	One 100,000-employee company	Scale	~INR 1.5 lakh	~$1,670	~INR 3.0 lakh ($3,380)
Step 3	One 1,000,000-employee company	Enterprise	~INR 14.8 lakh	~$14,700 at list	~INR 27.8 lakh ($31,560)

Every unexplained day gets a phone call. If most are settled on WhatsApp first, call volume and these costs fall by about half.

1. Prices used

Plivo (India)

- Domestic number rental: INR 200 a month.
- Domestic calls, outbound and inbound: INR 0.38 a minute, billed in 30-second pulses. Calls carried over the SIP trunk to LiveKit are costed at the same rate in the app (*src/lib/costs/prices.ts*).
- No monthly platform fee or minimum is published.

LiveKit Cloud

	Build	Ship	Scale	Enterprise
Monthly fee	$0	$50	$500	Custom
Agent calls at once	5	20	Up to 600	Custom
Connections at once	100	1,000	5,000	Custom
SIP minutes included	1,000 (stops past this)	5,000	50,000	Custom
SIP minutes beyond	—	$0.004	$0.003	Custom
WebRTC minutes included	5,000	150,000	1.5M	Custom
WebRTC minutes beyond	—	$0.0005	$0.0004	Custom
Agent session minutes	1,000 included	5,000 incl., then $0.01	50,000 incl., then $0.01	Custom

LiveKit bills by the whole minute. The app is set to the Build plan today (*LIVEKIT_PLAN* is unset and defaults to *build*). Ship and Scale fees are "starting at" figures.

2. Cost per call and per employee

Item	Working	Per call
Plivo line	~3.5 billed minutes × INR 0.38	~INR 1.33
LiveKit SIP	~4 billed minutes × $0.003–0.004	~INR 1.06–1.41
LiveKit WebRTC	Within the included minutes until Step 3	~0
Total		**~INR 2.4–2.7**

At ~1.1 calls per employee a month that is **~INR 2.6–3.0 per employee per month**.

To confirm with LiveKit. The app assumes its agent, which runs on Azure rather than on LiveKit's own agent hosting, is not charged as "agent session minutes". If LiveKit does count it, add ~4 minutes × $0.01 = **~INR 3.5 per call**. That takes the total to ~INR 6 per call and ~INR 6.5 per employee per month, and the step totals below rise accordingly. The same question decides whether the "agent calls at once" cap applies.

3. Cost at each step

Calls a month = employees × 5% × 22 working days. Billed minutes: ~3.5 a call on Plivo, ~4 on LiveKit.

	Today (1,000)	Step 1 (10,000)	Step 2 (100,000)	Step 3 (1,000,000)
Calls a month	~1,100	~11,000	~110,000	~1.1M
Calls at once at peak	1–2	~15	~150	~1,250
Plivo minutes	~3,850	~38,500	~385,000	~3.85M
Plivo minutes cost	INR 1,460	INR 14,630	INR 1,46,300	INR 14,63,000
Plivo numbers (suggested)	1 · INR 200	5 · INR 1,000	20 · INR 4,000	100+ · INR 20,000
LiveKit plan	Ship, $50	Ship, $50	Scale, $500	Enterprise, custom
LiveKit SIP beyond plan	$0 (4,400 of 5,000)	39,000 min · $156	390,000 min · $1,170	4.35M min · $13,050
LiveKit WebRTC beyond plan	$0	$0	$0	2.9M min · $1,160
Plivo total	~INR 1,700	~INR 15,600	~INR 1,50,300	~INR 14,83,000
LiveKit total	~$50 (INR 4,400)	~$206 (INR 18,100)	~$1,670 (INR 1,47,000)	~$14,710 at list (INR 12.9 lakh)
Fixed part	$50 + INR 200	$50 + INR 1,000	$500 + INR 4,000	Negotiated
Together	**~INR 6,100**	**~INR 33,700**	**~INR 2.97 lakh**	**~INR 27.8 lakh**

- **Today.** The Build plan allows 1,000 SIP minutes a month (~250 calls) and stops rather than charging beyond that. It covers a company of about 200 employees; a 1,000-employee customer needs Ship.
- **Step 1.** ~15 calls at once fits Ship's 20. Plivo's default limits are enough.
- **Step 2.** ~150 calls at once needs Scale. Plivo's default ~50 calls at once must be raised through Plivo sales.
- **Step 3.** ~1,250 calls at once is beyond Scale, so Enterprise pricing applies; list rates are shown as a ceiling. Plivo must raise both calls at once and new calls per second (~7 a second at peak).

4. Limits to raise at each step

These caps decide whether calls can be placed at all, and matter more than price.

Limit	Default	Today	Step 1	Step 2	Step 3
Plivo new calls per second (SIP trunk)	2 per account, 1 per trunk	OK	OK	OK (~0.7 at peak)	Raise (~7 at peak)
Plivo calls at once (India)	~50	OK	OK	Raise (~150)	Raise (~1,250)
LiveKit agent calls at once	5 / 20 / 600 by plan	Ship: 20 (Build: 5)	Ship: 20	Scale: 600	Enterprise
LiveKit SIP minutes	1,000 / 5,000 / 50,000 incl.	Build stops at 1,000	Overage	Overage	Negotiated

Plivo's documentation is not fully consistent on these defaults; confirm the account's actual limits with Plivo. Calls over the trunk's per-second limit fail immediately, while calls over the account limit queue.

5. Ways to bring the cost down

- **WhatsApp first.** Calling only those who don't reply on WhatsApp roughly halves call volume and both bills.
- **Shorter calls.** Plivo bills in 30-second pulses and LiveKit by the whole minute, so trimming a call from 3.5 to 2.5 minutes saves ~30%.
- **Volume pricing.** From Step 2, ask Plivo for a committed-volume rate and LiveKit for annual Scale pricing.
- **Run LiveKit yourself at Step 3.** The LiveKit server is open source. At ~1M call minutes a month, running it on Azure (a few VMs or AKS) would likely cost far less than Enterprise pricing. It moves the cost into Azure compute and adds operational work.

6. For the budget

Line	How to plan for it
Fixed	LiveKit plan fee ($0 / $50 / $500 / custom) plus Plivo number rental (INR 200 a number)
Per employee	~INR 3 a month for calls; ~INR 6.5 if LiveKit counts agent session minutes
Drivers	Share of employees called each day, call length, and how many cases WhatsApp settles first

Sources: livekit.com/pricing; plivo.com/voice/pricing/in; plivo.com/docs/sip-trunking/concepts/technical-specifications; plivo.com/docs/voice/concepts/account-limits. Rates as used by the app: src/lib/costs/prices.ts.